Hunting & Fishing Safety Guide

Safety essentials for hunting and fishing in Pierce County and the Cascade backcountry

Pierce County's diverse terrain — from lowland forests to alpine basins — offers excellent hunting and fishing opportunities. But hunters and anglers often travel deeper into remote territory than other recreationists, frequently solo, in conditions where help is hours away. Our SAR unit responds to hunting-related incidents regularly.

Pierce County Hunting & Fishing Areas

Game Management Units

Pierce County falls primarily within WDFW Game Management Units 654 (Rainier) and 653 (Mashel). Black bear, blacktail deer, elk, mountain goat, and cougar are all present. Check WDFW regulations (wdfw.wa.gov) for season dates, tag requirements, and access.

National Forest Lands

The Mt. Baker-Snoqualmie and Gifford Pinchot National Forests offer extensive public hunting access. Many forest service roads are gated seasonally. Check USFS MVUMs for current road access. Some areas require special permits during fire season.

Rivers & Lakes for Fishing

The Puyallup, Carbon, Nisqually, and White Rivers offer steelhead, salmon, and trout fishing. Mountain lakes (Mowich, Eunice, many unnamed alpine lakes) hold stocked trout. WDFW fishing regulations vary by water body — check before you go.

Hunter Safety

Firearm Safety in the Field

- ☐ Muzzle control: Always point in a safe direction. Know what's beyond your target.
- ☐ Identify your target: 100% positive identification before firing. No shooting at sounds or movement.
- ☐ Blaze orange: Required during modern firearm seasons. Minimum 400 sq inches of fluorescent orange.
- ☐ Tree stands: Use a full-body harness. More hunting injuries come from tree stand falls than any other cause.
- ☐ Loaded firearms: Unload when climbing, crossing fences/obstacles, or entering vehicles/camp.

Solo Hunting Risks

Many hunters go solo — it's part of the experience. But it dramatically increases risk. A fall, an equipment failure, or a medical event with no one to help can turn fatal. If you hunt solo, the following are NON-NEGOTIABLE:

- ☐ File a DETAILED trip plan: exact area, ridgeline, drainage you'll be hunting
- ☐ Carry a satellite communicator (Garmin inReach, Zoleo, or sign up for free satellite 911)
- ☐ Check in on a strict schedule with your emergency contact
- ☐ Carry a comprehensive first aid kit including a tourniquet and pressure dressing
- ☐ Know how to self-splint and self-evacuate for lower extremity injuries

SAR PRO TIP

The most common solo hunting SAR scenario: a hunter takes a fall in steep terrain, injures a leg or ankle, and can't hike out. They're miles from a road with no cell service. Without a satellite communicator, we don't know they're in trouble until they're overdue — which could be days. A $15/month Garmin inReach subscription is cheap life insurance.

Backcountry Fishing Safety

Wading Safety

Glacial rivers in Pierce County are cold (40-55°F), silty, and swift. Felt-soled waders provide better traction than rubber on slippery river rocks. Use a wading staff. Never wade above your knees in fast current. Wear a wading belt to prevent water from filling your waders if you fall — waterlogged waders can drag you under.

Remote Lake Fishing

Alpine lake fishing often requires significant hiking to reach. Apply all hiking safety guidelines (Ten Essentials, trip plan, offline maps). Afternoon thunderstorms are common at elevation in summer. Get off the water and away from exposed ridges if you hear thunder.

Game Processing & Pack-Out Safety

After a successful harvest, the work begins — and so do the risks. Pack-out is physically demanding and often happens in fading light when you're already tired.

- ☐ Weight: Quarter your game in the field if possible. Multiple lighter loads are safer than one heavy one.
- ☐ Footing: Blood and game fat on rocks and logs create extreme slip hazards. Take your time.
- ☐ Bears: Gut piles and game meat attract bears. Be aware, make noise, carry bear spray.
- ☐ Daylight: Start early. Don't try to pack out in the dark on steep terrain. Bivouac if needed.
- ☐ Hydration: Pack-out is a serious workout. Bring extra water and high-calorie food.

Emergency Checklist for Hunters & Anglers

- ☐ Trip plan filed: hunting area, specific drainages/ridgelines, vehicle location, return date
- ☐ Satellite communicator or free satellite 911 texting enrolled
- ☐ First aid kit with tourniquet, pressure dressings, SAM splint
- ☐ Fire starting materials in waterproof container
- ☐ Emergency shelter (bivy or space blanket) — you may need to overnight unexpectedly
- ☐ Offline maps with your planned area + bail-out routes downloaded
- ☐ Blaze orange visible from all directions (helps SAR find you too)
- ☐ Headlamp + extra batteries (lithium for cold weather reliability)
- ☐ Extra food and water beyond what you plan to consume

SATELLITE 911 TEXTING

T-Mobile offers satellite 911 texting — FREE for all carriers (emergency 911 only). Full satellite messaging is $10/mo. Hunting areas have essentially ZERO cell coverage. Sign up at t-mobile.com/coverage/satellite-phone-service/911-texting-signup